

Meeting with WD

May 26/26

NLTA members present: Steve Chippett, President & Perry Warren, VP

WD Reps: Shelley Moores and Don Keefe

Minutes prepared by: Steve Chippett

Meeting began at 10:00AM in conference room at provincial building in Corner Brook

Introductions were made. Shelley noted that this was her first meeting with the NLTA in her three years as WD Director and expressed a desire for more regular engagement. The group agreed to meet at least quarterly, with additional meetings as needed.

The group discussed the need for a shift in mindset, viewing trapping as a fur industry rather than simply as a hobby.

Trapper Education

We were advised that trainers met in Deer Lake in March 2026 to review possible updates to the trapper education courses. No decision has been made yet, although an online hybrid model is being considered. The group also discussed the current number of trained trappers in the province, which is believed to be between 2,500 and 3,000. It was decided that trapper education courses would be paused until the actual number of trained trappers can be confirmed. The number of courses the NLTA is required to offer each year under its contract with WD will also be confirmed at the next meeting.

The group also discussed whether people should be required to complete the full trapping course in order to set bear snares. We will look at changing the requirement so that individuals do not need to complete the full course or receive a full trapper license solely to set a bear snare. Both sides agreed that changes are needed.

Beaver

Beaver permits were discussed. The NLTA expressed concern that issuing beaver trapping permits to individuals may enable poaching or theft on registered beaver lines. Previously, anyone without a registered beaver line were not permitted to possess beaver; however, this is no longer the case. Both WD representatives understood the concern and agreed that the issue would be discussed further at the next meeting.

The group also discussed nuisance beaver trapping and noted that it can cost trappers money to remove beavers during the off-season or when pelts are not prime. Compensation for trappers was discussed, as it would reduce hesitation from trappers around removing nuisance beavers. NLTA representatives explained that it costs WD more to remove beavers directly than it would to pay a fee to the registered trapper, as is done in other provinces. There was agreement around the table on this issue. More to be discussed at the next meeting.

Beaver returns were also discussed, including concerns that the online process is complicated. This issue will be revisited at the next meeting, with a focus on making the process more user friendly. WD officials reiterated that trappers need to provide accurate and timely information, as this data helps guide decisions about the fur industry. We were also advised that the NLTA would be involved in any government decisions related to the fur industry.

Lynx

The group discussed the length of the lynx season. Labrador has a five-month season, while the island has only a one-month season. NLTA representatives also raised concerns that lynx numbers on the island are higher than WD's current estimates. The idea of having NLTA members from each region of the province help prepare a survey was discussed and was well received by WD. This topic will be discussed further at a future stand-alone meeting on lynx.

Bear

Bear trapping training, as noted above, was discussed and will be addressed in more detail at a future stand-alone meeting on trapper education. The group also discussed the possibility of increasing the Labrador bear license from a permit to harvest four bears to one allowing up to eight bears. The discussion was positive, and the idea remains open for further consideration.

The group discussed the importance of increasing membership numbers and building strength in numbers. WD indicated that it is willing to help distribute materials, such as pamphlets with trapper licenses, podcasts, and other promotional items.

A copy of the minutes from the 49th AGM was left with the WD representatives, although not all issues and resolutions in the minutes were not discussed.

The next meeting was planned for some time in August 2026. WD requested separate meetings on lynx, beaver, and trapper education topics.

The NLTA thanked Shelley and Don for their time and look forward to meeting again in August.

The meeting ended at 11:38 a.m